

COVER STORY UK ATTACKS

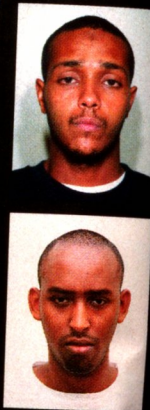
database of 'individuals of potential interest' shared by MI5, MI6 (which is concerned with overseas intelligence) and GCHQ (the government centre that monitors communications), these were discovered only through the interception of conversations on mobile phones and e-mails, not through the networks of the police or security service surveillance in the UK. "We can't watch everybody, obviously. We have limited resources and have to make choices," said one intelligence source. "If you join enough dots between sympathisers with radical Islam, they are all joined up anyway."

The other question was about the nature of the plot. Recent thinking on militancy in the UK is that the threat comes more from 'home-grown' terrorists— young British citizens who have been radicalised by militant Islamic propaganda and who seek out the means to mount their own terrorist operation— than trained operatives 'parachuted in' from abroad. This conclusion is based on the profiles of the 150-or-so militants either convicted or facing charges for their roles in a variety of plots including the 7/7 attacks, the recent trial of those who attempted to use fertiliser bombs for mass casualty attacks in London and the scheme to bring down trans-Atlantic passenger jets last year. In almost all these cases, the vast proportion of those arrested were young, male Britons of Pakistani descent. In recent years, only the so-called Ricin Plot involved a majority of foreigners. 'Londonistan', largely populated by foreigners, has been replaced by a far more potent threat: self-radicalising Britons. "For a long time we looked for the enemy without, now it's the enemy within," said one former intelligence agent, now a security consultant.

This week terrorism stayed on the front pages of the UK's newspapers, with the conviction of four members of an Islamist terror cell found guilty of plotting suicide bombings of London's Underground two weeks after the successful attacks of 7/7. The strike, potentially devastating, failed due to technical faults and "sheer good luck". The four men were not, as with many other plots, drawn from the UK's Pakistani immigrant community, but



JUNE 30, 2007 The attack on Glasgow, where a fuel-filled jeep rammed into the airport, was one of at least three foiled terrorist plans in the last two years alone



WATCHFUL EYE An armed policeman patrols Heathrow Airport, London. Following the attack on the Glasgow airport, security has been beefed up in the United Kingdom.

were from war-torn countries in the Horn of Africa, though they had lived in the UK for many years. Aged between 25 and 29, the four lived on the margins of society and spent a year planning their eventually abortive attack.

Yet, their ringleader too had, like the leader of the 7/7 bombers, made at least one trip to a training camp in Pakistan. With backgrounds in delinquency, drug-abuse and benefit fraud, the group's profile was very different